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Zande theology

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"Zande names which contain the work 'Mbori' when viewed in the light of their method of naming in general cannot be used as evidence for the existence of a formulated doctrine defining Mbori as a supreme and beneficent father or of conscious devotion of Azande towards him, for they are in origin little more than idiomatic expressions of satisfaction and in use no more than names are to us.

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It is necessary.... to know not merely that such names [JMA: see 551, 3: Lagae--68] are occasionally given to children, but also the context of their endowment. The name Ngbamboligbe may have been given as a joke or out of a feeling of exuberance, and there is no reason why we should suppose that it was given out of a feeling of gratitude or respect.... I have never observed that Azande show any more sense of awe when uttering names in which Mbori occurs than we have in uttering such names as Christopher. I was only able to trace the occurrence which suggested the endowment of a name in a single instance. One of my [20] informants was named Mborizingbare (Mbori has closed my lips). I asked the youth's father, prince Rikita, why he had called his son by this name, and he said that when he was asked by what name he would call his son he made this reply which meant 'I really cannot think what to say.' "

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